# 6 | Three Points of Agreement

This book focuses primarily on our disagreements about nuclear weapons proliferation in South Asia. First, we develop competing theoretical accounts of proliferation's strategic effects. Ganguly argues that nuclear weapons, because of their inherent destructive properties, induce even the most intransigent adversaries to exercise restraint and prevent the escalation of violent conflicts. Kapur's strategic pessimism maintains that nuclear weapons, by providing a shield against all-out retaliation and attracting international attention, can increase the incentive for weak, dissatisfied powers to engage in destabilizing behavior. Second, we show how our theoretical approaches explain past Indo-Pakistani strategic behavior. Ganguly argues that the nuclearization of the subcontinent actually reduced the possibilities of full-scale war between the two long-standing adversaries. Cognizant of the dangers of nuclear escalation, both sides chose to exercise restraint and pursue a peace process. According to Kapur, nuclear weapons contributed to rising regional tensions during the proliferation process, facilitating the outbreak of significant Indo-Pakistani militarized crises and playing only a limited role in their resolution. Finally, we examine the current South Asian security environment and offer predictions regarding the future. Ganguly argues that reductions in Indo-Pakistani tensions stemmed in large part from India's willingness to resort to a strategy of coercive diplomacy in the aftermath of the Pakistan-based terrorist attacks in December 2001. India adopted this strategy largely because embarking on a conventional war against Pakistan invited the possibility of nuclear escalation. He also maintains that nuclear deterrence is likely to ensure regional stability in the future. Kapur claims that recent